

The Pit and the Pendulum

Edgar Allan Poe · 1842

First published: The Gift for 1843 (1842)

TEACHER EDITION · CURRICULUM UNIT

Common Core edition (standards shown for this framework only)

One 90-minute lesson (the whole story), with an optional take-home essay

Syllabus · 90-minute lesson plans · lecture scripts · vocabulary · quizzes with keys · writing prompts at eleven rigor levels · SAT-style items · whole-book test · essays

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Contents and unit overview

1. Unit overview and the 90-minute lesson
2. Syllabus (weekly pacing)
3. Lesson 1: introduction (author, context, reception, overview)
4. Lesson plans and lecture scripts (chapters 1–1), each with vocabulary, discussion questions, annotation focus, quiz and key, writing prompts and SAT-style items
5. Unit test (eleven rigor versions) with answer keys and scoring guides
6. Final paper
7. Essay assignments at eleven rigor levels

Edition: Reading text: https://en.wikisource.org/wiki/The_Works_of_the_Late_Edgar_Allan_Poe_(1850)/Volume_1/The_Pit_and_the_Pendulum (revision 14833577), cleaned for Liber et Libri.

Grades: Grades 9–12 (scales to graduate via rigor levels). Short story: read whole in one 90-minute lesson (assign longer stories as pre-reading). The scaffolded-support track works from the full text with scaffolds. **Weeks:** 1. **Class days:** 2 × 90 minutes (1 chapter lessons plus seminar, test and essay days).

Essential questions

- What does The Pit and the Pendulum suggest about terror and endurance?
- What does The Pit and the Pendulum suggest about the mind under torture?
- What does The Pit and the Pendulum suggest about rescue and hope?

Objectives

- Students will cite at least 2 quotations, with locations, to support each written claim about what the text says explicitly and implicitly (scored on the writing-prompt rubric).
- Students will trace one theme across at least 3 sections of the story in the final paper, earning at least 70 of 100 rubric points.
- Students will explain how characters, setting and point of view interact in at least 3 exit tickets, each meeting the claim-evidence-reasoning criteria.
- Students will determine the in-context meaning of taught vocabulary, scoring at least 80% on the vocabulary items of the story quizzes.
- Students will write an argument with a clear claim, reasons and relevant evidence, scoring at least 80% on the unit test's short-answer scoring guides.

Standards: Common Core

RL.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2, RL.9-10.3, RL.9-10.4, RL.9-10.5, RL.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2, RL.11-12.4, RL.11-12.5, W.9-10.1, W.11-12.1, L.9-10.4, L.11-12.4

Common Core State Standards (ELA-Literacy), thecorestandards.org

Assessments: Daily story quizzes (auto-graded); Weekly writing prompt (rubric); Socratic seminars (scheduled days); Whole-story test (scheduled day); Final essay (scheduled day); College Sophomore and above write one essay of the five
Differentiation: Every prompt and quiz has eleven rigor levels (Scaffolded support through Graduate / PhD); the app applies student override, then class standard, then the automatic level. Each prompt is tagged for Common Core, Indiana 2023, Dual Credit (Indiana College Core), AP and Cambridge where they apply.
Materials: Liber et Libri reader; Annotation journal; Story lecture slides or script

The 90-minute lesson

#	Segment	Mode	Minutes	Clock
1	Bell-ringer	You do	8	0–8
2	Vocabulary with etymology notes	I do	10	8–18
3	Background and context	I do	10	18–28
4	I do: modeled close reading	I do	12	28–40
5	We do: guided annotation	We do	15	40–55
6	You do: independent annotation	You do	15	55–70
7	Discussion	We do	10	70–80
8	Exit ticket / chapter quiz	You do	7	80–87
9	Closure	I do	3	87–90
	Total		**90**	

Syllabus

Week	Chapters	Lessons	Focus and activities	Assessment
1	*Introduction: author, context and reception* The Pit and the Pendulum	2 × 90 min (180 min)	*terror and endurance* • Daily 90-minute lesson: bell-ringer, vocabulary and word histories, background, I do / We do / You do, discussion, exit ticket, closure • Story quizzes in the app • Introduction: author, context and reception • Writing prompt at assigned rigor (one graded per week)	Quiz average plus one graded writing prompt

Lesson plans and lecture scripts

Each chapter is one 90-minute class. Scripts are a starting point; adapt them to your students. Teacher summaries contain spoilers.

Lesson 1: Introduction to The Pit and the Pendulum

Objective: Students will explain, in a 3-sentence exit ticket, how one fact about Edgar Allan Poe's life or times connects to terror and endurance in “The Pit and the Pendulum”, and will set up a reading journal with a prediction and a question for each of 3 themes (terror and endurance, the mind under torture, rescue and hope).

Standards: Common Core RL.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2

Author biography

Edgar Allan Poe was born in Boston on 19 January 1809 to touring actors; orphaned before he was three, he was raised in Richmond, Virginia, by the merchant John Allan, with whom he later quarrelled bitterly. He attended the University of Virginia, served in the U.S. Army and was dismissed from West Point, then lived by his pen as a poet, critic and magazine editor (the Southern Literary Messenger, Graham's Magazine) in Richmond, Philadelphia and New York. He married his young cousin Virginia Clemm, who died of tuberculosis in 1847. "The Raven" (1845) made him famous but never prosperous. He is credited with inventing the modern detective story ("The Murders in the Rue Morgue," 1841) and argued that a short story should create a single "unity of effect." He died in Baltimore on 7 October 1849; the cause of his death is unknown.

Historical and cultural context

The story is set in Toledo, Spain, during the Spanish Inquisition, which tried heretics from 1478 until its abolition in 1834. Poe drew on popular (often exaggerated) Protestant accounts of Inquisition tortures. The ending refers to the French General Lasalle entering Toledo during the Napoleonic wars (1808).

Publication and reception, then and now

First published in The Gift: A Christmas and New Year's Present for 1843 (an annual issued in late 1842).

Then: Admired for its sustained suspense.

Now: A model of suspense built through sensory detail and pacing; often adapted for film.

Overview (spoiler-free)

A prisoner condemned by the Inquisition wakes in total darkness and must work out the shape of his cell and the traps designed to kill him.

Main themes

- fear and suspense: the story is an experiment in terror.
- reason against terror: he survives by observation and thought.
- cruelty of institutions: the torturers are never seen.

Why it matters

It teaches how writers control pacing, and it raises questions about torture and the abuse of power.

Spoilers · teacher only

He avoids a pit, escapes a slowly descending blade by letting rats chew his bonds, and as heated walls force him toward the pit he is rescued by the French army.

Lesson plan (90 minutes)

0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)
Students write to the bell-ringer, then pair-share.
Before we open The Pit and the Pendulum: What is scarier: what you can see, or what you can't?
Prompt: Before we open The Pit and the Pendulum: What is scarier: what you can see, or what you can't?

8–18 min · Key terms · I do (10 min)
Key literary terms for the unit.
suspense; pacing; sensory imagery; deus ex machina; Inquisition.

18–28 min · Mini-lecture: author, context, reception · I do (10 min)
Mini-lecture on the author, the historical context and the reception (read or adapt the script).
About the author. Edgar Allan Poe was born in Boston on 19 January 1809 to touring actors; orphaned before he was three, he was raised in Richmond, Virginia, by the merchant John Allan, with whom he later quarrelled bitterly. He attended the University of Virginia, served in the U.S. Army and was dismissed from West Point, then lived by his pen as a poet, critic and magazine editor (the Southern Literary Messenger, Graham's Magazine) in Richmond, Philadelphia and New York. He married his young cousin Virginia Clemm, who died of tuberculosis in 1847. "The Raven" (1845) made him famous but never prosperous. He is credited with inventing the modern detective story ("The Murders in the Rue Morgue," 1841) and argued that a short story should create a single "unity of effect." He died in Baltimore on 7 October 1849; the cause of his death is unknown. The world of the book. The story is set in Toledo, Spain, during the Spanish Inquisition, which tried heretics from 1478 until its abolition in 1834. Poe drew on popular (often exaggerated) Protestant accounts of Inquisition tortures. The ending refers to the French General Lasalle entering Toledo during the Napoleonic wars (1808). Publication and reception. First published in The Gift: A Christmas and New Year's Present for 1843 (an annual issued in late 1842). Then: Admired for its sustained suspense. Now: A model of suspense built through sensory detail and pacing; often adapted for film.

28–40 min · I do: the book in one passage · I do (12 min)
Model a close reading of one passage using the written think-aloud below.
First, meaning. I read "sick unto death with that long agony" slowly and put it in my own words: The narrator says he was sick to death with long agony. Next, craft. I notice the old-fashioned "unto," which sounds biblical and grave. The strongest word is "agony": it is extreme pain of body and mind, the subject of the whole story. Then, effect. What does this phrase tell us about the narrator's state? My answer: Poe starts from exhaustion and suffering; the story will put us inside the mind of someone pushed to the edge of what a person can endure.

> *sick unto death with that long agony (The Pit and the Pendulum, paragraph 7)*

Think-aloud: First, meaning. I read "sick unto death with that long agony" slowly and put it in my own words: The narrator says he was sick to death with long agony. Next, craft. I notice the old-fashioned "unto," which sounds biblical and grave. The strongest word is "agony": it is extreme pain of body and mind, the subject of the whole story. Then, effect. What does this phrase tell us about the narrator's state? My answer: Poe starts from exhaustion and suffering; the story will put us inside the mind of someone pushed to the edge of what a person can endure.

40–55 min · We do: overview and themes · We do (15 min)
Read the spoiler-free overview together and name the themes to track.
What the book is about (no spoilers): A prisoner condemned by the Inquisition wakes in total darkness and must work out the shape of his cell and the traps designed to kill him. Themes to track: fear and suspense: the story is an experiment in terror. reason against terror: he survives by observation and thought. cruelty of institutions: the torturers are never seen.

55–70 min · You do: reading journal · You do (15 min)
Set up a reading journal: one page per theme, with a prediction and a question (example given).
Set up a reading journal: one page per theme with a prediction and a question. Page: the mind under torture. Prediction: the prisoner of the Inquisition will survive, if at all, by thinking clearly in the dark. Question: which details does Poe use to make me feel time passing slowly?
Task: Set up a reading journal for The Pit and the Pendulum: one page per theme, each with a prediction and a question.
Exemplar: Page: the mind under torture. Prediction: the prisoner of the Inquisition will survive, if at all, by thinking clearly in the dark. Question: which details does Poe use to make me feel time passing slowly?

70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)
Whole-class discussion: why the book is still taught.
Why does The Pit and the Pendulum still matter? It teaches how writers control pacing, and it raises questions about torture and the abuse of power.
Anchor question: Why might The Pit and the Pendulum still be taught today?
Facilitation: It teaches how writers control pacing, and it raises questions about torture and the abuse of power.

80–87 min · Exit ticket · You do (7 min)
Exit ticket on the author and context (answer given).
This story is set during the Spanish Inquisition, centuries before Poe wrote it. Why might Poe choose such a distant historical setting? Answer: Accept answers such as: the Inquisition was famous for torture and fear; a distant setting made horror believable but safe for readers; it lets him focus on suffering and power.
Exit ticket: This story is set during the Spanish Inquisition, centuries before Poe wrote it. Why might Poe choose such a distant historical setting?
Answer: Accept answers such as: the Inquisition was famous for torture and fear; a distant setting made horror believable but safe for readers; it lets him focus on suffering and power.

87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)
Preview the first reading.
Tomorrow we begin reading: The Pit and the Pendulum.

Teacher notes · sources: Poe Museum, Richmond, "Poe's Life" (https://poemuseum.org/poes-life/); Edgar Allan Poe Society of Baltimore (texts and publication history) (https://www.eapoe.org/); Poe Society of Baltimore, "The Pit and the Pendulum" (https://www.eapoe.org/works/tales/pitpenda.htm)

Flags (verify before teaching):

- Historians note that the specific tortures are Poe's invention, not documented Inquisition practice.

Lesson 2: The Pit and the Pendulum

Focus: reason struggling against terror

Objective: Students will analyze how imagery develops in "The Pit and the Pendulum" by writing a claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph that cites at least 2 quotations from the section, and will score at least 80% on the section quiz.

Standards: Common Core RL.9-10.4, W.9-10.1, L.9-10.4

Content note (torture, rats, alcohol or drugs (mentioned), suicide (mentioned in lesson text)): Sensitive content: Torture; rats. Preview the story, tell students in advance, and allow a pass on reading aloud. Keep discussion on how the writer uses these elements, not on graphic detail. This section mentions drinking or a drug ("…ght. It must have been drugged—for scarcely had I drunk, before I became irresistibly drowsy. A…"). Treat it as period custom or plot detail; name it plainly and don't glamorize it. This lesson mentions suicide or self-harm. Discuss the character's despair and what the text does with it; do not dwell on methods. Before the lesson, remind students that support is available and how to reach the counselor. Check in privately with any student who seems affected and follow your school's referral protocol.
Student preview: Heads-up: this story includes torture; rats.
Suggested language: "Why does the writer include this, and what does it make us notice?"
Safe messaging: Discuss the character's despair and what the text does with it; do not dwell on methods. Before the lesson, remind students that support is available and how to reach the counselor. Check in privately with any student who seems affected and follow your school's referral protocol. **Share with students:** If you or someone you know is struggling or thinking about suicide, call or text 988 (Suicide & Crisis Lifeline, U.S.) or talk with a school counselor today. Let a counselor know in advance that this chapter is being taught.

Teacher only · spoilers

Condemned by the Spanish Inquisition in Toledo, the narrator wakes in a pitch-dark cell. He narrowly avoids falling into a central pit, then wakes strapped beneath a razor-edged pendulum descending toward his heart. He smears food on his bonds so rats chew them free. The walls then glow red-hot and close in, forcing him toward the pit, until a French army takes Toledo and General Lasalle catches his arm.

Background: The Spanish Inquisition was ended by Napoleon's forces in 1808, and French troops did occupy Toledo. Poe's details are invented gothic horror, not history.

Significance: It is a sustained study of suspense built through sensory detail and the narrator's attempts to reason.

Lesson plan and lecture script (90 minutes)

0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)
Students write to the bell-ringer, then pair-share.
When you are afraid, what helps you think clearly? Write for five minutes. Starters: I think... because... / This connects to reason against terror because.... Content note before we start: Heads-up: this story includes torture; rats. If you or someone you know is struggling or thinking about suicide, call or text 988 (Suicide & Crisis Lifeline, U.S.) or talk with a school counselor today.
Prompt: When you are afraid, what helps you think clearly?
Sentence starters: I think… because… · This connects to reason against terror because…
Strong response: A strong response takes a position and anticipates this: measuring the cell and using the rats show reason defeating despair.

8–18 min · Vocabulary with etymology notes · I do (10 min)
Five key words in context, with verified word histories.
Today's words: avalanche — a slide of large masses of snow and ice and mud down a mountain; charnel — full of corpses, like a burial vault; dungeons — dark underground prison cells; wrestled — forced (its way) with a struggle; torrents — a heavy rain. "torrents": Origin of "torrent": French torrent; earlier Latin torrentem.
Words: avalanche: a slide of large masses of snow and ice and mud down a mountain · charnel: full of corpses, like a burial vault · dungeons: dark underground prison cells · wrestled: forced (its way) with a struggle · torrents: a heavy rain

18–28 min · Background and context · I do (10 min)
Mini-lecture (read or adapt the script).
The Spanish Inquisition was ended by Napoleon's forces in 1808, and French troops did occupy Toledo. Poe's details are invented gothic horror, not history. It is a sustained study of suspense built through sensory detail and the narrator's attempts to reason. Pacing: Long sentences slow time as the blade descends ("Down—steadily down it crept"); the countdown makes the reader count too. Imagery: Darkness, smell, touch and sound dominate before sight returns. Plot: Each escape leads to a worse trap, building to the walls' squeeze. Watch for the pendulum: time as an executioner.

28–40 min · I do: modeled close reading · I do (12 min)
Model the close reading of the anchor quotation using the written think-aloud below.
First, meaning. I read "Down—steadily down it crept" slowly and put it in my own words: The narrator watches the blade come lower and lower, steadily. Next, craft. I notice the dash and the repetition of "down," which make the sentence itself drop in slow steps. The strongest word is "crept": creeping is slow and sly, and it makes the blade seem alive and patient. Then, effect. How does Poe make the pendulum's movement feel slow? My answer: Poe makes the pendulum's movement feel slow by repeating "down" and stretching the sentence, so we feel every inch; the slowness is the torture, and the suspense comes from waiting, not speed.

> *Down—steadily down it crept* (*The Pit and the Pendulum, paragraph 31*)

Think-aloud: First, meaning. I read "Down—steadily down it crept" slowly and put it in my own words: The narrator watches the blade come lower and lower, steadily. Next, craft. I notice the dash and the repetition of "down," which make the sentence itself drop in slow steps. The strongest word is "crept": creeping is slow and sly, and it makes the blade seem alive and patient. Then, effect. How does Poe make the pendulum's movement feel slow? My answer: Poe makes the pendulum's movement feel slow by repeating "down" and stretching the sentence, so we feel every inch; the slowness is the torture, and the suspense comes from waiting, not speed.

40–55 min · We do: guided annotation · We do (15 min)
Guided analysis of a second quotation; expected answers given.
Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest? Expected: The last line: history, not reason, delivers him. Look at the craft: Darkness, smell, touch and sound dominate before sight returns. Ask: How does this line connect to reason against terror? Expected: Measuring the cell and using the rats show reason defeating despair. (The last line: history, not reason, delivers him.)

> *The Inquisition was in the hands of its enemies* (*The Pit and the Pendulum, paragraph 44*)

Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest?
Expected answer: The last line: history, not reason, delivers him. Look at the craft: Darkness, smell, touch and sound dominate before sight returns.
Ask: How does this line connect to reason against terror?
Expected answer: Measuring the cell and using the rats show reason defeating despair. (The last line: history, not reason, delivers him.)

55–70 min · You do: independent annotation · You do (15 min)

Independent annotation and a claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph (exemplar given).

Annotate the story for pacing, imagery (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this story suggest about reason struggling against terror? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how The Pit and the Pendulum develops the idea of reason struggling against terror. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of imagery and structure shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.) Exemplar: Poe builds suspense by slowing time to the speed of the blade. When the text says "Down—steadily down it crept" (The Pit and the Pendulum, paragraph 31), it shows this directly. The repeated "Down—steadily down it crept" makes the reader endure each swing, so the escape feels earned even though the final rescue, "An outstretched arm caught my own," comes from outside.

Task: Annotate the story for pacing, imagery (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this story suggest about reason struggling against terror? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how The Pit and the Pendulum develops the idea of reason struggling against terror. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of imagery and structure shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.)

Exemplar: Poe builds suspense by slowing time to the speed of the blade. When the text says "Down—steadily down it crept" (The Pit and the Pendulum, paragraph 31), it shows this directly. The repeated "Down—steadily down it crept" makes the reader endure each swing, so the escape feels earned even though the final rescue, "An outstretched arm caught my own," comes from outside.

70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)

Structured discussion from the 30 tiered questions, with facilitation notes.

Anchor question: When you are afraid, what helps you think clearly? Ask: what does the prisoner do that a panicked person would not?

Anchor question: When you are afraid, what helps you think clearly?

Facilitation: Ask: what does the prisoner do that a panicked person would not?

80–87 min · Exit ticket / chapter quiz · You do (7 min)

Story quiz in the app and an exit ticket (answer given).

Story quiz in the app, then: In one sentence, what does this story suggest about reason struggling against terror? Support it with one short quotation. Model answer: Poe builds suspense by slowing time to the speed of the blade. ("Down—steadily down it crept", The Pit and the Pendulum, paragraph 31). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the story; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.

Exit ticket: In one sentence, what does this story suggest about reason struggling against terror? Support it with one short quotation.

Answer: Model answer: Poe builds suspense by slowing time to the speed of the blade. ("Down—steadily down it crept", The Pit and the Pendulum, paragraph 31). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the story; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.

> **87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)**
> Summarize the lesson and preview the next reading.
> *Today we saw how pacing shapes reason struggling against terror. Key takeaway: measuring the cell and using the rats show reason defeating despair.*

Total: 90 minutes.

Teacher analysis (spoilers)

Literary elements

- **Pacing:** Long sentences slow time as the blade descends ("Down—steadily down it crept"); the countdown makes the reader count too.
- **Imagery:** Darkness, smell, touch and sound dominate before sight returns.
- **Plot:** Each escape leads to a worse trap, building to the walls' squeeze.

Themes and how they develop

- **reason against terror:** measuring the cell and using the rats show reason defeating despair.

Symbols and motifs

- **the pendulum:** time as an executioner.

Key quotations (checked against the reading text)

- "Down—steadily down it crept" (The Pit and the Pendulum, paragraph 31) Pacing of the descent.
- "The Inquisition was in the hands of its enemies" (The Pit and the Pendulum, paragraph 44) The last line: history, not reason, delivers him.
- "An outstretched arm caught my own as I fell, fainting, into the abyss" (The Pit and the Pendulum, paragraph 44) The rescue.

Model claim-evidence-reasoning

> **Claim:** Poe builds suspense by slowing time to the speed of the blade.
> **Evidence:** "Down—steadily down it crept" (The Pit and the Pendulum, paragraph 31)
> **Reasoning:** The repeated "Down—steadily down it crept" makes the reader endure each swing, so the escape feels earned even though the final rescue, "An outstretched arm caught my own," comes from outside.

Vocabulary with etymology notes

Word	Definition (in this sentence)	In context	Word history
avalanche (noun)	a slide of large masses of snow and ice and mud down a mountain	*I might as well have attempted to arrest an avalanche!*	

charnel (adjective)	full of corpses, like a burial vault	*The entire surface of this metallic enclosure was rudely daubed in all the hideous and repulsive devices to which the charnel superstition of the monks has given rise.*	
dungeons (noun)	dark underground prison cells	*Of the dungeons there had been strange things narrated—fables I had always deemed them—but yet strange, and too ghastly to repeat, save in a whisper.*	
wrestled (verb)	forced (its way) with a struggle	*At length it forced—it wrestled its way into my soul—it burned itself in upon my shuddering reason.*	
torrents (noun)	a heavy rain	*A fearful idea now suddenly drove the blood in torrents upon my heart, and for a brief period, I once more relapsed into insensibility.*	"torrents": Origin of "torrent": French torrent; earlier Latin torrentem. (Liber et Libri origin note, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/torrent#Etymology)
encompassed (verb)	surrounded	*The blackness of eternal night encompassed me.*	
ascertaining (verb)	finding out for certain	*This process, however, afforded me no means of ascertaining the dimensions of my dungeon; as I might make its circuit, and return to the point whence I set out, without being aware of the fact; so perfectly uniform seemed the wall.*	"ascertaining": Origin of "ascertain": Middle English acerteynen; earlier Old French acertener. (Liber et Libri origin note, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/ascertain#Etymology)
cessation (noun)	a stopping	*At first, the ravenous animals were startled and terrified at the change—at the cessation of movement.*	"cessation": Origin: Middle French cessation; earlier Latin cessātiō. (Liber et Libri origin note, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/cessation#Etymology)
narrated (verb)	provide commentary for a film, for example	*Of the dungeons there had been strange things narrated—fables I had always deemed them—but yet strange, and too ghastly to repeat, save in a whisper.*	
barriers (noun)	a structure or object that impedes free movement	*With that thought I rolled my eyes nervously around on the barriers of iron that hemmed me in.*	"barriers": Origin of "barrier": Anglo-Norman barrere. (Liber et Libri origin note, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/barrier#Etymology)

Discussion questions

1. When you are afraid, what helps you think clearly?
2. Where does imagery appear in this story, and what effect does it have? Point to one passage.
3. How does this story connect to the book's larger concern with terror and endurance?

Classroom discussion questions (30, tiered)

Wait time after every question (3 s for DOK 1, 5 s for DOK 2, 8 to 10 s for DOK 3 and 4); think-pair-share on DOK 3 and 4; answer each response with a follow-up probe; close with student-generated questions. Focus sets by rigor level: Scaffolded support: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 11, 12, 13, 14, 21, 22; HS Freshman: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 12, 13, 14, 15, 22, 23, 24; HS Sophomore: 1, 2, 3, 4, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 23, 24, 25; HS Junior: 1, 2, 3, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18, 24, 25, 26, 27; HS Senior: 1, 2, 3, 15, 16, 17, 18, 25, 26, 27, 28, 29; AP: 1, 2, 16, 17, 18, 19, 20, 26, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Freshman: 1, 2, 17, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Sophomore: 1, 2, 11, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 28, 29, 30; College Junior: 1, 11, 12, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 29, 30; College Senior: 1, 11, 12, 13, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 30; Graduate / PhD: 1, 11, 12, 13, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 27, 28

Literal / recall

1. Who has condemned the narrator? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: The Inquisition
2. How does the narrator first discover the pit? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: He trips and falls with his face at its edge
3. How does he escape the pendulum? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: He rubs food on his straps so rats gnaw them
4. What do the walls do? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Glow red-hot and close in
5. Who rescues the narrator? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: General Lasalle and the French army
6. Retell the three most important events of “The Pit and the Pendulum” in order, in one sentence each. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Condemned by the Spanish Inquisition in Toledo, the narrator wakes in a pitch-dark cell. He narrowly avoids falling into a central pit, then wakes strapped beneath a razor-edged pendulum descending toward his heart. He smears food on his bonds so rats chew them free. The walls then glow red-hot and close in, forcing him toward the pit, until a French army takes Toledo and General Lasalle catches…
7. Which characters appear or are mentioned in “The Pit and the Pendulum”? Name two and one thing each says or does. [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Names and actions taken from the story; check against the teacher summary.
8. Where and when does “The Pit and the Pendulum” take place? Point to the line that tells you. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: A place/time detail quoted from the story.
9. Reread: “I might as well have attempted to arrest an avalanche!” What does “avalanche” mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: avalanche: a slide of large masses of snow and ice and mud down a mountain.
10. Reread: “The entire surface of this metallic enclosure was rudely daubed in all the hideous and repulsive devices to which the charnel superstition of the monks has given rise.” What does “charnel” mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: charnel: full of corpses, like a burial vault.

Inferential / analytical

1. What does “The Pit and the Pendulum” suggest about reason struggling against terror? State the inference and the line that supports it. [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: It is a sustained study of suspense built through sensory detail and the narrator's attempts to reason.
2. Find one example of imagery in this story. What does it reveal that a plain statement would not? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.4, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.4] Look for: Look for sensory details (sight, sound, cold, light) and what mood they create.
3. How does the structure in this story shape what we understand about reason struggling against terror? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: Look for how the story is ordered and why it begins and ends where it does.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Poe builds suspense by slowing time to the speed of the blade. Useful evidence: “Down—steadily down it crept” (The Pit and the Pendulum, paragraph 31): Pacing of the descent. Theme link: measuring the cell and using the rats show reason defeating despair. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
4. In the passage that begins “And now, as I still continued to step cautiously onward, there came thronging upon my recollection a thousand vague rumors of the horrors of Toledo.”, why might Poe have chosen these particular words? Pick two and explain their connotations. [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.4, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.4] Look for: Diction analysis of two words in the anchor passage.
5. What causes the main turn in “The Pit and the Pendulum”, and what effect is it likely to have on what follows? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: Condemned by the Spanish Inquisition in Toledo, the narrator wakes in a pitch-dark cell. He narrowly avoids falling into a central pit, then wakes strapped beneath a razor-edged pendulum descending toward his heart. He smears food on his bonds so rats chew them free. The walls then glow red-hot and…
6. As the opening story, what does “The Pit and the Pendulum” set up that the rest of The Pit and the Pendulum will need? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: A causal or structural link between this and the previous story.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Poe builds suspense by slowing time to the speed of the blade. Useful evidence: “The Inquisition was in the hands of its enemies” (The Pit and the Pendulum, paragraph 44): The last line: history, not reason, delivers him. Theme link: measuring the cell and using the rats show reason defeating despair. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
7. What can we infer about a character's motives from what they say and do here, as opposed to what they claim? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: An inference about motive supported by a quoted line.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Poe builds suspense by slowing time to the speed of the blade. Useful evidence: “An outstretched arm caught my own as I fell, fainting, into the abyss” (The Pit and the Pendulum, paragraph 44): The rescue. Theme link: measuring the cell and using the rats show reason defeating despair. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

8. The bell-ringer asked: "When you are afraid, what helps you think clearly?" Now that we have read closely, how would you revise your first answer, and which line changed your mind? [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A revised answer anchored in the text.
9. Where does point of view appear, and how does it connect this story to the larger concern with terror and endurance? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.6] Look for: Look for who is telling the story and what that narrator can and cannot know.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Poe builds suspense by slowing time to the speed of the blade. Useful evidence: "Down—steadily down it crept" (The Pit and the Pendulum, paragraph 31): Pacing of the descent. Theme link: measuring the cell and using the rats show reason defeating despair. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
10. Background: The Spanish Inquisition was ended by Napoleon's forces in 1808, and French troops did occupy Toledo. Poe's details are invented gothic horror, not history. How does knowing this change the way you read one moment in the story? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: A specific moment reread in light of the context.
    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Poe builds suspense by slowing time to the speed of the blade. Useful evidence: "The Inquisition was in the hands of its enemies" (The Pit and the Pendulum, paragraph 44): The last line: history, not reason, delivers him. Theme link: measuring the cell and using the rats show reason defeating despair. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Evaluative / synthesis / creative

1. A critic might argue: "It is a sustained study of suspense built through sensory detail and the narrator's attempts to reason." How far do you agree? Take a stand and defend it with two lines from the story. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A defended position with evidence and one counterpoint.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Poe builds suspense by slowing time to the speed of the blade. Useful evidence: "An outstretched arm caught my own as I fell, fainting, into the abyss" (The Pit and the Pendulum, paragraph 44): The rescue. Theme link: measuring the cell and using the rats show reason defeating despair. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
2. Which character in this story acts most wisely, and which least? Judge them by a standard you name. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: An evaluation using an explicit criterion and evidence.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Poe builds suspense by slowing time to the speed of the blade. Useful evidence: "Down—steadily down it crept" (The Pit and the Pendulum, paragraph 31): Pacing of the descent. Theme link: measuring the cell and using the rats show reason defeating despair. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
3. Rewrite one moment of "The Pit and the Pendulum" from the point of view of a different character. What does the new angle reveal or hide about reason struggling against terror? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.6] Look for: A creative product with a rationale tied to the text.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Poe builds suspense by slowing time to the speed of the

blade. Useful evidence: “The Inquisition was in the hands of its enemies” (The Pit and the Pendulum, paragraph 44): The last line: history, not reason, delivers him. Theme link: measuring the cell and using the rats show reason defeating despair. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

4. Write three questions of your own about “The Pit and the Pendulum”: one recall, one “why/how”, and one “should/what if”. Trade with a partner and answer theirs. [DOK 3 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: Student-generated questions at three levels.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Poe builds suspense by slowing time to the speed of the blade. Useful evidence: “An outstretched arm caught my own as I fell, fainting, into the abyss” (The Pit and the Pendulum, paragraph 44): The rescue. Theme link: measuring the cell and using the rats show reason defeating despair. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

5. Connect this story to the mind under torture: is the link strong or weak so far? What would Poe need to show next to strengthen it? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A judgment of thematic development across the work.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Poe builds suspense by slowing time to the speed of the blade. Useful evidence: “Down—steadily down it crept” (The Pit and the Pendulum, paragraph 31): Pacing of the descent. Theme link: measuring the cell and using the rats show reason defeating despair. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

6. Is the imagery in this story effective, or does it feel heavy-handed? Evaluate it as a reader would in a review. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.4, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.4] Look for: An evaluative judgment with criteria and evidence.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Poe builds suspense by slowing time to the speed of the blade. Useful evidence: “The Inquisition was in the hands of its enemies” (The Pit and the Pendulum, paragraph 44): The last line: history, not reason, delivers him. On imagery: Darkness, smell, touch and sound dominate before sight returns. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

7. Compare how “The Pit and the Pendulum” treats reason struggling against terror with how another text, film or event you know treats a similar idea. What does The Pit and the Pendulum see that the other misses? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A cross-text synthesis.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Poe builds suspense by slowing time to the speed of the blade. Useful evidence: “An outstretched arm caught my own as I fell, fainting, into the abyss” (The Pit and the Pendulum, paragraph 44): The rescue. Theme link: measuring the cell and using the rats show reason defeating despair. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

8. As the final story, does this ending resolve terror and endurance? Argue whether the ending is earned. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: A prediction or judgment justified with textual clues.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Poe builds suspense by slowing time to the speed of the blade. Useful evidence: “Down—steadily down it crept” (The Pit and the Pendulum, paragraph 31): Pacing of the descent. Theme link: measuring the cell and using the rats show reason defeating despair. Credit any

position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

9. Design a one-paragraph modern adaptation of this story (setting, characters, conflict). What must stay the same for it to still be about reason struggling against terror? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A creative transfer that keeps the core idea.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Poe builds suspense by slowing time to the speed of the blade. Useful evidence: "The Inquisition was in the hands of its enemies" (The Pit and the Pendulum, paragraph 44): The last line: history, not reason, delivers him. Theme link: measuring the cell and using the rats show reason defeating despair. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

10. What question would you most like to ask Edgar Allan Poe about this story, and what answer do you think the text itself gives? [DOK 4 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A student-generated question answered from evidence.

    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Poe builds suspense by slowing time to the speed of the blade. Useful evidence: "An outstretched arm caught my own as I fell, fainting, into the abyss" (The Pit and the Pendulum, paragraph 44): The rescue. Theme link: measuring the cell and using the rats show reason defeating despair. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Annotation focus

- **Imagery:** look for sensory details (sight, sound, cold, light) and what mood they create (anchor passage in the We do segment)
- Also notice **Structure**: how the story is ordered and why it begins and ends where it does
- Also notice **Point of view**: who is telling the story and what that narrator can and cannot know

Chapter quiz: item bank (all eleven rigor versions)

1. [mc · recall · DOK 1] How does the narrator first discover the pit?

   A. He trips and falls with his face at its edge

   B. A guard shows him

   C. He sees it by torchlight

   D. He hears water drip

   Key: A (He trips and falls with his face at its edge)

2. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: "The blackness of eternal night _____ me." Word bank: dungeons, charnel, avalanche, encompassed

   Key: encompassed

3. [mc · recall · DOK 1] What do the walls do?

   A. Collapse

   B. Glow red-hot and close in

   C. Turn to glass

   D. Flood with water

   Key: B (Glow red-hot and close in)

4. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: "At first, the ravenous animals were startled and terrified at the change—at the _____ of movement." Word bank: charnel, avalanche, cessation, dungeons

   Key: cessation

5. [mc · recall · DOK 1] How does he escape the pendulum?

   A. He rubs food on his straps so rats gnaw them

   B. He breaks the chains

   C. A guard frees him

   D. He stops the gear

   Key: A (He rubs food on his straps so rats gnaw them)

6. [mc · recall · DOK 1] Who rescues the narrator?

   A. His brother

   B. A priest

   C. The rats' owner

   D. General Lasalle and the French army

   Key: D (General Lasalle and the French army)

7. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Complete the quotation from The Pit and the Pendulum, paragraph 44: "An _____ arm caught my own as I fell, fainting, into the abyss"

   Key: outstretched

8. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: "A fearful idea now suddenly drove the blood in _____ upon my heart, and for a brief period, I once more relapsed into insensibility." Word bank: charnel, avalanche, torrents, dungeons

   Key: torrents

9. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: "This process, however, afforded me no means of _____ the dimensions of my dungeon; as I might make its circuit, and return to the point whence I set out, without being aware of the fact; so perfectly uniform seemed the wall." Word bank: avalanche, dungeons, charnel, ascertaining

   Key: ascertaining

10. [mc · recall · DOK 1] Who has condemned the narrator?

    A. The Inquisition

    B. A king

    C. A rival family

    D. A pirate captain

    Key: A (The Inquisition)

11. [short · inference · DOK 2] What can you infer from this line? "Down—steadily down it crept" (The Pit and the Pendulum, paragraph 31) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: Pacing of the descent.

12. [short · inference · DOK 2] What can you infer from this line? "The Inquisition was in the hands of its enemies" (The Pit and the Pendulum, paragraph 44) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: The last line: history, not reason, delivers him.

13. [mc · inference · DOK 2] Which choice best states a central concern of “The Pit and the Pendulum”?

    A. Reason struggling against terror

    B. Reason defeating a hidden crime

    C. A wife's quiet rebellion for a decent home

    D. A story so convincing it becomes real

    Key: A (Reason struggling against terror)

14. [mc · analysis · DOK 3] Which literary element does this describe in “The Pit and the Pendulum”? Darkness, smell, touch and sound dominate before sight returns.

    A. Metaphor

    B. Imagery

    C. Foreshadowing

    D. Irony

    Key: B (Imagery)

15. [short · analysis · DOK 3] Claim: Poe builds suspense by slowing time to the speed of the blade. Explain how this evidence supports the claim: “Down—steadily down it crept” (The Pit and the Pendulum, paragraph 31).

    Sample answer: The repeated "Down—steadily down it crept" makes the reader endure each swing, so the escape feels earned even though the final rescue, "An outstretched arm caught my own," comes from outside.

16. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Evaluate this claim about the story: “Poe builds suspense by slowing time to the speed of the blade.” Is it fully persuasive? Argue with evidence, including a passage that complicates it.

    Sample answer: The repeated "Down—steadily down it crept" makes the reader endure each swing, so the escape feels earned even though the final rescue, "An outstretched arm caught my own," comes from outside.

17. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Complete the quotation from The Pit and the Pendulum, paragraph 44: “The _____ was in the hands of its enemies”

    Key: Inquisition

18. [mc · analysis · DOK 3] Which literary element does this describe in “The Pit and the Pendulum”? Long sentences slow time as the blade descends ("Down—steadily down it crept"); the countdown makes the reader count too.

    A. Characterization

    B. Foreshadowing

    C. Pacing

    D. Setting

    Key: C (Pacing)

19. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Synthesis: trace how reason against terror develops from an earlier story to “The Pit and the Pendulum”. Use one quotation from each.

    Sample answer: measuring the cell and using the rats show reason defeating despair.

20. [short · analysis · DOK 3] Analyze the word choice in “An outstretched arm caught my own as I fell, fainting, into the abyss” (The Pit and the Pendulum, paragraph 44). Pick two words and explain what they suggest.

    Sample answer: The rescue.

21. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of "Down—steadily down it crept" (The Pit and the Pendulum, paragraph 31) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.
    Sample answer: Pacing of the descent.
22. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of "The Inquisition was in the hands of its enemies" (The Pit and the Pendulum, paragraph 44) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.
    Sample answer: The last line: history, not reason, delivers him.
23. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line "The entire surface of this metallic enclosure was rudely daubed in all the hideous and repulsive devices to which the charnel superstition of the monks has given rise.", what does "charnel" most nearly mean?
    A. a slide of large masses of snow and ice and mud down a mountain
    B. forced (its way) with a struggle
    C. dark underground prison cells
    D. full of corpses, like a burial vault

    Key: D (full of corpses, like a burial vault)
24. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line "Of the dungeons there had been strange things narrated—fables I had always deemed them—but yet strange, and too ghastly to repeat, save in a whisper.", what does "dungeons" most nearly mean?
    A. full of corpses, like a burial vault
    B. a slide of large masses of snow and ice and mud down a mountain
    C. forced (its way) with a struggle
    D. dark underground prison cells

    Key: D (dark underground prison cells)
25. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line "I might as well have attempted to arrest an avalanche!", what does "avalanche" most nearly mean?
    A. dark underground prison cells
    B. a slide of large masses of snow and ice and mud down a mountain
    C. forced (its way) with a struggle
    D. full of corpses, like a burial vault

    Key: B (a slide of large masses of snow and ice and mud down a mountain)

Rigor version	Items (in order)	Mix
Scaffolded support	1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 7, 8, 9, 10, 11, 12, 13, 14, 15, 16	recall 10, inference 3, analysis 2, synthesis 1
HS Freshman	10, 2, 6, 5, 17, 4, 9, 8, 7, 13, 12, 11, 18, 15, 14, 19	recall 9, inference 3, analysis 3, synthesis 1
HS Sophomore	1, 10, 5, 2, 17, 4, 3, 9, 13, 12, 11, 18, 20, 15, 21, 16	recall 8, inference 3, analysis 3, synthesis 2
HS Junior	4, 3, 17, 6, 10, 9, 7, 11, 13, 12, 15, 14, 20, 18, 16, 21	recall 7, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 2
HS Senior	1, 5, 6, 17, 4, 8, 11, 13, 12, 18, 15, 20, 14, 16, 21, 22	recall 6, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 3
AP	23, 7, 9, 2, 4, 12, 11, 13, 14, 15, 18, 20, 16, 19, 21, 22	recall 5, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
College Freshman	24, 1, 25, 2, 4, 13, 12, 11, 20, 14, 18, 15, 19, 21, 16, 22	recall 5, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4

College Sophomore	10, 8, 4, 3, 17, 12, 13, 11, 20, 14, 15, 18, 21, 16, 19, 22	recall 5, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
College Junior	8, 25, 2, 1, 23, 11, 12, 13, 20, 15, 14, 18, 22, 19, 21, 16	recall 5, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
College Senior	7, 8, 5, 23, 24, 11, 13, 12, 20, 18, 15, 14, 16, 22, 19, 21	recall 5, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
Graduate / PhD	1, 4, 7, 23, 9, 13, 11, 12, 18, 14, 20, 15, 22, 21, 16, 19	recall 5, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4

Writing prompts (eleven rigor levels)

Scaffolded support (250 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.4, W.9-10.1): Supported track (work from the passage your teacher selects). In “The Pit and the Pendulum,” how does Poe show reason struggling against terror? Write a paragraph that states your claim, quotes two details from the passage, and explains how each detail supports your idea. Use the imagery you noticed as one piece of evidence.

HS Freshman (350 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.4, W.9-10.1): In The Pit and the Pendulum, how does Poe develop the idea of reason struggling against terror? State a clear claim, support it with two or three quotations, and explain how the imagery in the story helps build that idea.

HS Sophomore (450 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.4, W.9-10.1): Analyze how The Pit and the Pendulum develops the idea of reason struggling against terror. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of imagery and structure shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.

HS Junior (550 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.5, RL.11-12.1, W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.9): Analyze how the structure of The Pit and the Pendulum (where it begins, turns and ends) and its imagery shape the reader's understanding of reason struggling against terror. Identify one place where the text leaves matters uncertain and explain how that uncertainty adds to its meaning.

HS Senior (600 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.4, W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.9): Two readers disagree about what The Pit and the Pendulum suggests about reason struggling against terror. Lay out two plausible interpretations, weigh the evidence for each (including the story's imagery and structure), and argue for the stronger one in a sustained, well-organized essay.

AP (650 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.4, W.11-12.1): Write a literary argument in which you analyze how Edgar Allan Poe uses imagery in The Pit and the Pendulum to complicate the reader's understanding of reason struggling against terror. Develop a defensible thesis, select evidence purposefully, and explain how specific choices of diction and syntax create meaning.

College Freshman (1000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Situate The Pit and the Pendulum within its historical and literary context and argue how the story's treatment of reason struggling against terror responds to that context. Engage with at least one secondary perspective (a critic, historian or the author's own statements), integrate quotations smoothly, and cite in MLA style.

College Sophomore (1250 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Read The Pit and the Pendulum alongside the conventions of its genre and period. Argue how the story's handling of reason struggling against terror follows or bends those conventions, using the imagery as evidence, and test your reading against one published critic. Document two secondary sources in MLA.

College Junior (1500 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Apply a named critical approach (for example formalist, historicist, feminist, psychoanalytic or ecocritical) to The Pit and the Pendulum and its treatment of reason struggling against terror. State your method, show what it reveals in the story's imagery and structure, and identify where the text resists it.

College Senior (2000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Develop a research argument that reads The Pit and the Pendulum as evidence for a larger claim about reason struggling against terror in The Pit and the Pendulum. Connect close reading of the story to the whole story, engage at least four scholarly sources, and state precisely where your reading departs from theirs (Chicago style).

Graduate / PhD (2500 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Develop an original argument that reads The Pit and the Pendulum as a hinge in the story's larger treatment of reason struggling against terror. Position your reading within a named critical conversation (for example formalist, historicist, psychoanalytic, feminist or postcolonial approaches), account for the textual history where relevant, and articulate the stakes of your intervention for scholarship on The Pit and the Pendulum.

SAT-style questions

1. *Of the dungeons there had been strange things narrated—fables I had always deemed them—but yet strange, and too ghastly to repeat, save in a whisper.*

   As used in the text, what does the word “dungeons” most nearly mean?

   A. provide commentary for a film, for example

   B. dark underground prison cells

   C. a stopping

   D. a structure or object that impedes free movement

2. *And now, as I still continued to step cautiously onward, there came thronging upon my recollection a thousand vague rumors of the horrors of Toledo. Of the dungeons there had been strange things narrated—fables I had always deemed them—but yet strange, and too ghastly to repeat, save in a whisper. Was I left to perish of starvation in this subterranean world of darkness; or what fate, perhaps even more fearful, awaited me? That the result would be death, and a death of more than customary bitterness, I knew too well the character of my judges to doubt. The mode and the hour were all that occupied or distracted me.*

   Which choice best states a central concern of “The Pit and the Pendulum”?

   A. A reversal that punishes a change of heart

   B. Science that poisons love

   C. Reason struggling against terror

   D. The foolishness of wishing to be young again

SAT key: 1. B (dark underground prison cells); 2. C (Reason struggling against terror)

Unit test

The Pit and the Pendulum: end test · 90 minutes · 18 questions per rigor version (multiple choice, fill in the blank, short answer). The class rigor level picks the version; student auto-adjust applies.

Short-answer scoring guides

Scaffolded support and HS Freshman (2 points): correct answer in a complete sentence with a detail from the text. HS Sophomore to HS Senior (3 points): claim, one accurate quotation, one sentence of explanation. AP to College Sophomore (4 points): precise claim, two embedded quotations, commentary on word choice or structure, link to theme. College Junior to Graduate (5 points): nuanced thesis, close reading of two passages, synthesis across sections, a competing reading answered. Each item lists a sample answer; partial credit is described in the app.

Unit test: item bank (all eleven rigor versions)

1. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “The blackness of eternal night _____ me.” Word bank: dungeons, charnel, avalanche, encompassed

   Key: encompassed

2. [mc · recall · DOK 1] How does the narrator first discover the pit?

   A. He trips and falls with his face at its edge

   B. A guard shows him

   C. He sees it by torchlight

   D. He hears water drip

   Key: A (He trips and falls with his face at its edge)

3. [mc · recall · DOK 1] How does he escape the pendulum?

   A. He rubs food on his straps so rats gnaw them

   B. He breaks the chains

   C. A guard frees him

   D. He stops the gear

   Key: A (He rubs food on his straps so rats gnaw them)

4. [mc · recall · DOK 1] Who has condemned the narrator?

   A. The Inquisition

   B. A king

   C. A rival family

   D. A pirate captain

   Key: A (The Inquisition)

5. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Complete the quotation from The Pit and the Pendulum, paragraph 44: “An _____ arm caught my own as I fell, fainting, into the abyss”

   Key: outstretched

6. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “At first, the ravenous animals were startled and terrified at the change—at the _____ of movement.” Word bank: charnel, avalanche, cessation,

dungeons

Key: cessation

7. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “A fearful idea now suddenly drove the blood in _____ upon my heart, and for a brief period, I once more relapsed into insensibility.” Word bank: charnel, avalanche, torrents, dungeons

   Key: torrents

8. [mc · recall · DOK 1] Who rescues the narrator?

   A. His brother

   B. A priest

   C. The rats' owner

   D. General Lasalle and the French army

   Key: D (General Lasalle and the French army)

9. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Complete the quotation from The Pit and the Pendulum, paragraph 44: “The _____ was in the hands of its enemies”

   Key: Inquisition

10. [mc · recall · DOK 1] What do the walls do?

    A. Collapse

    B. Glow red-hot and close in

    C. Turn to glass

    D. Flood with water

    Key: B (Glow red-hot and close in)

11. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “This process, however, afforded me no means of _____ the dimensions of my dungeon; as I might make its circuit, and return to the point whence I set out, without being aware of the fact; so perfectly uniform seemed the wall.” Word bank: avalanche, dungeons, charnel, ascertaining

    Key: ascertaining

12. [short · inference · DOK 2] What can you infer from this line? “Down—steadily down it crept” (The Pit and the Pendulum, paragraph 31) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: Pacing of the descent.

13. [short · inference · DOK 2] What can you infer from this line? “The Inquisition was in the hands of its enemies” (The Pit and the Pendulum, paragraph 44) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: The last line: history, not reason, delivers him.

14. [mc · inference · DOK 2] Which choice best states a central concern of “The Pit and the Pendulum”?

    A. Reason struggling against terror

    B. Reason defeating a hidden crime

    C. A wife's quiet rebellion for a decent home

    D. A story so convincing it becomes real

    Key: A (Reason struggling against terror)

15. [short · analysis · DOK 3] Claim: Poe builds suspense by slowing time to the speed of the blade. Explain how this evidence supports the claim: “Down—steadily down it crept” (The Pit and the Pendulum, paragraph 31).

Sample answer: The repeated "Down—steadily down it crept" makes the reader endure each swing, so the escape feels earned even though the final rescue, "An outstretched arm caught my own," comes from outside.

16. [mc · analysis · DOK 3] Which literary element does this describe in “The Pit and the Pendulum”? Long sentences slow time as the blade descends ("Down—steadily down it crept"); the countdown makes the reader count too.

    A. Characterization

    B. Foreshadowing

    C. Pacing

    D. Setting

    Key: C (Pacing)

17. [short · analysis · DOK 3] Analyze the word choice in “An outstretched arm caught my own as I fell, fainting, into the abyss” (The Pit and the Pendulum, paragraph 44). Pick two words and explain what they suggest.
    Sample answer: The rescue.

18. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Evaluate this claim about the story: “Poe builds suspense by slowing time to the speed of the blade.” Is it fully persuasive? Argue with evidence, including a passage that complicates it.
    Sample answer: The repeated "Down—steadily down it crept" makes the reader endure each swing, so the escape feels earned even though the final rescue, "An outstretched arm caught my own," comes from outside.

19. [mc · analysis · DOK 3] Which literary element does this describe in “The Pit and the Pendulum”? Darkness, smell, touch and sound dominate before sight returns.

    A. Metaphor

    B. Imagery

    C. Foreshadowing

    D. Irony

    Key: B (Imagery)

20. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “The Inquisition was in the hands of its enemies” (The Pit and the Pendulum, paragraph 44) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.
    Sample answer: The last line: history, not reason, delivers him.

21. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “Down—steadily down it crept” (The Pit and the Pendulum, paragraph 31) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.
    Sample answer: Pacing of the descent.

22. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Synthesis: trace how reason against terror develops from an earlier story to “The Pit and the Pendulum”. Use one quotation from each.
    Sample answer: measuring the cell and using the rats show reason defeating despair.

23. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “At length it forced—it wrestled its way into my soul—it burned itself in upon my shuddering reason.”, what does “wrestled” most nearly mean?

    A. full of corpses, like a burial vault

    B. a slide of large masses of snow and ice and mud down a mountain

    C. dark underground prison cells

    D. forced (its way) with a struggle

    Key: D (forced (its way) with a struggle)

24. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line "The entire surface of this metallic enclosure was rudely daubed in all the hideous and repulsive devices to which the charnel superstition of the monks has given rise.", what does "charnel" most nearly mean?

    A. a slide of large masses of snow and ice and mud down a mountain

    B. forced (its way) with a struggle

    C. dark underground prison cells

    D. full of corpses, like a burial vault

    Key: D (full of corpses, like a burial vault)

25. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line "I might as well have attempted to arrest an avalanche!", what does "avalanche" most nearly mean?

    A. dark underground prison cells

    B. a slide of large masses of snow and ice and mud down a mountain

    C. forced (its way) with a struggle

    D. full of corpses, like a burial vault

    Key: B (a slide of large masses of snow and ice and mud down a mountain)

26. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line "Of the dungeons there had been strange things narrated—fables I had always deemed them—but yet strange, and too ghastly to repeat, save in a whisper.", what does "dungeons" most nearly mean?

    A. full of corpses, like a burial vault

    B. a slide of large masses of snow and ice and mud down a mountain

    C. forced (its way) with a struggle

    D. dark underground prison cells

    Key: D (dark underground prison cells)

Rigor version	Items (in order)	Mix
Scaffolded support	1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 7, 8, 9, 10, 11, 12, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18	recall 11, inference 3, analysis 3, synthesis 1
HS Freshman	1, 3, 2, 8, 10, 5, 7, 4, 6, 11, 9, 13, 14, 12, 16, 19, 15, 20	recall 11, inference 3, analysis 3, synthesis 1
HS Sophomore	9, 11, 6, 4, 2, 7, 10, 5, 1, 8, 12, 13, 14, 15, 19, 16, 21, 22	recall 10, inference 3, analysis 3, synthesis 2
HS Junior	8, 6, 1, 10, 3, 11, 7, 2, 4, 13, 14, 12, 17, 16, 19, 15, 20, 21	recall 9, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 2
HS Senior	8, 10, 11, 2, 6, 9, 7, 4, 13, 12, 14, 15, 17, 19, 16, 20, 22, 18	recall 8, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 3
AP	4, 9, 1, 2, 8, 5, 23, 13, 12, 14, 17, 19, 15, 16, 20, 22, 21, 18	recall 7, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
College Freshman	7, 8, 9, 10, 11, 24, 1, 13, 14, 12, 15, 17, 19, 16, 21, 20, 18, 22	recall 7, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4

College Sophomore	11, 7, 23, 6, 1, 8, 2, 13, 12, 14, 19, 16, 17, 15, 18, 22, 21, 20	recall 7, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
College Junior	23, 4, 25, 9, 2, 5, 6, 12, 14, 13, 15, 19, 16, 17, 22, 21, 20, 18	recall 7, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
College Senior	23, 1, 2, 3, 24, 6, 5, 14, 12, 13, 15, 16, 19, 17, 18, 20, 21, 22	recall 7, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
Graduate / PhD	11, 26, 6, 2, 9, 25, 7, 13, 12, 14, 15, 19, 17, 16, 22, 20, 21, 18	recall 7, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4

Final paper

The Pit and the Pendulum: final paper (formal literary analysis). Choose one prompt.

1. Analyze how Edgar Allan Poe develops terror and endurance across The Pit and the Pendulum. Trace the idea through at least three moments (beginning, middle and end) and argue what the ending finally suggests.
2. Choose one recurring symbol, image or motif in The Pit and the Pendulum and argue how its meaning changes over the story and why that change matters to the mind under torture.
3. Analyze a central character's choices in The Pit and the Pendulum. Argue whether the story judges that character, and how its structure or point of view shapes your answer.
4. Two readers disagree about whether The Pit and the Pendulum finally endorses or criticizes its society's view of rescue and hope. Weigh both readings and argue for one, answering the strongest objection.

Length: Scaffolded support 500-700 words; HS Freshman 700-900 words; HS Sophomore 900-1,100 words; HS Junior 1,000-1,300 words; HS Senior 1,200-1,500 words; AP 1,300-1,600 words; College Freshman 1,500-2,000 words; College Sophomore 2,000-2,500 words; College Junior 2,500-3,000 words; College Senior 3,000-4,000 words; Graduate / PhD 4,000-6,000 words

Evidence requirement: at least 4 quotations from at least two parts of the story. Quote the reading text exactly and cite the paragraph (MLA style). HS Senior and above: one scholarly or historical source; College Sophomore and above: two, cited in MLA.

Criterion	Points	Descriptor
Thesis	20	A specific, arguable claim that answers the prompt and organizes the paper.
Evidence	25	Well-chosen, accurately quoted and cited passages from across the work, meeting the evidence requirement.
Analysis	30	Explains how language, structure and literary elements create meaning; goes beyond summary.
Organization	15	Logical progression, clear topic sentences and transitions; introduction and conclusion frame the argument.
Style and conventions	10	Formal academic voice, present tense for literature, correct grammar and MLA format.

Essay assignments

Essay: Terror and endurance

Scaffolded support (600 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Supported track: write a five-paragraph essay explaining what The Pit and the Pendulum teaches about terror and endurance. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Edgar Allan Poe develops terror and endurance in The Pit and the Pendulum. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Edgar Allan Poe develops terror and endurance across The Pit and the Pendulum. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of The Pit and the Pendulum (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of terror and endurance. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of terror and endurance in The Pit and the Pendulum. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Edgar Allan Poe's choices in The Pit and the Pendulum (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of terror and endurance, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places The Pit and the Pendulum's treatment of terror and endurance in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on terror and endurance in The Pit and the Pendulum that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on terror and endurance in The Pit and the Pendulum. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about terror and endurance in The Pit and the Pendulum, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on terror and endurance in The Pit and the Pendulum, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Essay: The mind under torture

Scaffolded support (600 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Supported track: write a five-paragraph essay explaining what The Pit and the Pendulum teaches about the mind under torture. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Edgar Allan Poe develops the mind under torture in The Pit and the Pendulum. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Edgar Allan Poe develops the mind under torture across The Pit and the Pendulum. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of The Pit and the Pendulum (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of the mind under torture. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of the mind under torture in The Pit and the Pendulum. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Edgar Allan Poe's choices in The Pit and the Pendulum (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of the mind under torture, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places The Pit and the Pendulum's treatment of the mind under torture in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on the mind under torture in The Pit and the Pendulum that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on the mind under torture in The Pit and the Pendulum. Name your critical method, apply it closely,

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Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on the mind under torture in The Pit and the Pendulum, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Essay: Rescue and hope

Scaffolded support (600 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Supported track: write a five-paragraph essay explaining what The Pit and the Pendulum teaches about rescue and hope. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Edgar Allan Poe develops rescue and hope in The Pit and the Pendulum. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Edgar Allan Poe develops rescue and hope across The Pit and the Pendulum. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of The Pit and the Pendulum (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of rescue and hope. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of rescue and hope in The Pit and the Pendulum. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Edgar Allan Poe's choices in The Pit and the Pendulum (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of rescue and hope, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places The Pit and the Pendulum's treatment of rescue and hope in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on rescue and hope in The Pit and the Pendulum that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

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Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

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